

HAMBURGER BUNS

MAKES TWELVE LARGE HAMBURGER BUNS.

Hamburgers are among my favorite things to eat, and I have specific ideas about what makes a good one. Beyond the perfect patty and supercrisp iceberg lettuce, the bun is crucial. I don't like most people's ideas of "fancy" hamburgers—I don't like hamburgers on grilled bread or on rustic baguettes, even ones from my own bakery. My perfect burger is more of a junk-food burger—there *was* a time when fast-food burgers were actually good. The bun should be soft, but not so soft it falls apart. It should smoosh into the burger as you bite in.

When I decided to bake hamburger buns for the bakery, I chose a dough similar to the one I use for the Raisin Brioche. The high fat content keeps the bread moist. It's not the ideal junk-food bun of my youth, but it's close.

THREE-DAY BREAD—FIRST AND SECOND DAYS

1 recipe Raisin Brioche Dough, minus raisins (see page 120)

Follow the first-day and second-day directions for Raisin Brioche dough, without the raisins.

THIRD DAY

HAVE READY:

Proofing cloth

Dough cutter

Spray bottle, filled with water

2 baking sheets lined with parchment paper

Long-stemmed, instant-read cooking thermometer

Pastry brush

Raisin Brioche dough

Unbleached white bread flour for dusting

¾ cup sesame seeds, optional

Remove the dough from the refrigerator and take off the plastic wrap. The dough should have almost doubled in size. If it hasn't doubled, leave the dough out at room temperature covered with a cloth until it has.

Turn the dough out onto a lightly floured work surface and cut it into twelve 4½-ounce pieces with a dough cutter. Tuck under the edges of each piece, cover them with a cloth, and let the dough rest for 15 minutes.

Working with one piece at a time, and keeping the rest covered with a cloth, shape the dough into balls by cupping your hand lightly around the dough and rounding it against the friction of the work surface to form a smooth bun. Begin slowly and increase speed as the ball becomes tighter and smoother. Use as little flour as possible to prevent sticking. If there is not enough friction between the work surface and the dough, spritz the work surface lightly with water from a spray bottle.

As each bun is shaped, check to be sure it is smooth and taut and the surface of the dough is not torn, which would indicate overrounding. Place the buns at least 2 inches apart, smooth side up, on parchment-lined baking sheets. Press down gently on each bun to flatten it into a disk. Cover the buns with a cloth and let them proof at room temperature until they nearly double in size and reach an internal temperature of 68 degrees F, approximately 3 hours.

Preheat the oven to 500 degrees F 1 hour before baking. Be sure the oven racks are placed well apart to allow plenty of air circulation.

Brush the tops of the buns with water and sprinkle each with 2 teaspoons of sesame seeds.

Open the oven door, spritz the oven heavily with water from a spray bottle, and quickly close the door. Open the oven door again, load both baking sheets onto the racks, and quickly close the door.

Reduce the oven temperature to 400 degrees F. Spritz the oven two more times during the next 5 minutes. Refrain from opening the oven door for the next 10 minutes.

After 10 minutes, check the buns and rotate them if necessary to ensure even baking. Continue baking until the buns are golden brown and nicely puffed, 10 to 15 more minutes, for a total baking time of 25 to 30 minutes. Remove the buns from the oven and allow to cool.

VARIATION:

Instead of sprinkling the buns with sesame seeds, try using poppy seeds, black sesame seeds, sprigs of herbs such as fresh chervil or thyme, or cracked black pepper.